

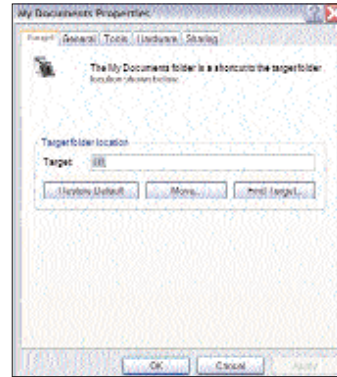
suggest is moving each of these “shell folders” to their own partitions. The good news is that you need not create a separate partition for all these. While we would recommend separating your videos and music to different locations, you should, at the very least, consider giving your My Documents folder its own little room on your hard drive. Since My Documents also lists the My Music and the My Videos folder, this is an encompassing move.

If you have multiple hard drives, you should consider moving the My Documents folder to its own partition on a separate hard disk from the one on which Windows is installed. While a separate partition in itself will reduce fragmentation, and allow for better data management, moving it to a separate disk will also give you performance benefits and a small degree of data safety—programs and your OS are more likely to access your OS/programs hard drive than the hard drive on which you move your shell folders to, potentially giving the latter drive a longer life.

So how do you move your My Documents folder? Simply right-click on the folder and click on Properties, then pick a target drive/partition under the Target folder location field. In our example, we are moving the folder to the H: drive which is located on a separate disk. In this case, the H: drive in itself will be your documents folder; specify H:\My Documents if you wish to locate it under the My Documents folder under the H drive.

If you are going to store your music in the My Music folder and your videos in My Videos, then make sure you give this partition plenty of free space. If you wish to store only your documents (Word files, Excel files, Outlook mail backups, PDFs, HTML files, files transferred over the MSN or Yahoo! Messengers, etc), allocating it 5 GB of space should be quite enough.

Offer as much space as you can to your music and movie partitions. We recommend using separate partitions for these—judge the space to be allocated based on the amount of content you have. If you are the kind who



Moving My Documents to the H drive

moves your data to optical media for storage/ backup purposes, you can give each 20 GB of space. If you like to keep it all on the hard disk, the more the better.

To move other special folders to a new location, right-drag the folder to its desired location and select “Move Here”. Note that you will need to move the Doc-

uments and Settings folder to another partition as well if you wish, at some point of time, to reinstall Windows XP without losing a program’s data.

On A Drive For More Partitions

If you are the gaming type, consider creating a separate partition for your games. No program will need a dedicated space more than your favourite games will. Those with multiple disks should consider moving the game’s partition to a separate drive.

Finally, we have the last piece to this jigsaw—the cache used by Windows XP. The OS creates a memory cache on your hard drive which it uses as a scratch pad. As you might know, when XP runs low on available system memory, it heads to this scratch pad to read and write temporary data to. You can do two things to improve performance here. Assign a dedicated partition to your cache on a separate hard drive, and fix the size of the assigned cache. As a rule of thumb, assign 1 GB more than your system memory for your Windows cache: if you have 512 MB of memory, give it about 1.5 GB; if you have 2 GB of RAM, make your cache 3 GB large. After you’ve created such a partition, right-click on My Computer, click on Properties, then on the Advanced tab, and then the Settings button under the Performance section.

Tips

❑ Which file system should you choose under Windows XP? FAT32 enjoys the widest support across operating systems and devices. NTFS, however, allows you to compress as well as encrypt your data

❑ The My Recent Documents listing on Open/Save dialog boxes is a godsend. Click on it and then type out the initial letters of a folder or a file for quick access to something you visit frequently. You can use a custom icon for each drive/partition. Create a file called autorun.inf on the root of each disk/partition and add this content to it:

```
[autorun]
icon="YourIconOfChoice.ico"
```

Save this file. Upon reboot, the disk in question will show the icon. Click on View > Icons under Windows Explorer for the best effect

❑ Metadata is vital if you wish to search and organise your content. Make sure that you add this information to the documents you create under Microsoft Office (File > Properties),

or the photographs you click, or the music you rip

❑ If you multiboot into Linux, consider creating a separate boot partition for Linux: assign about 60 MB of space on your primary drive and make sure that this is a primary partition and not an extended one. You can then mount /boot here and install your boot loader here instead of overwriting your Master Boot Record (MBR). To use Linux’s boot manager, use a partition tool (such as Partition Magic) to make /boot the active partition. If you uninstall Linux in the future, make sure you change the active partition back to Windows’ C: before you remove Linux. This will avoid headaches pertaining to an overwritten MBR

❑ If you have multiple hard drives and a motherboard with multiple IDE channels, install each of the main hard drives as masters on separate IDE channels, rather than slaving one to the other. A main hard drive can be one that hosts your operating system and your documents, for example. This will maximise system performance